Libby Kula

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RESEARCH AREAS

Environmental/Natural Resource Economics, Spatial Analysis

EDUCATION

Ph.D. Applied Economics, University of Minnesota, St. Paul, Minnesota.
ADVISORS: Stephen Polasky & Justin A. Johnson
DISSERTATION: *Essays on the Spatial, Temporal, and Socioeconomic Distribution of Urban Ecosystem Services in the United States*
DEGREE AWARDED: Sept. 2026

B.S. Economics & Mathematics, St. Catherine University, St. Paul, Minnesota, 2019. *Summa cum laude.*

PUBLICATIONS

Caroline Krafft, Kristine West, Ashley McFarlane, **Elizabeth Kula,** Fardowsa Abdinoor, Morgan Weyrens-Welch, and Karri Drain. 2022. "Virtually nonexistent: Gender and racial representation in online K-12 economics lessons." *Eastern Economic Journal.*

Caroline Krafft, **Elizabeth Kula,** and Maia Sieverding. 2021. "An investigation of Jordan's fertility stall and resumed decline: The role of proximate determinants." *Demographic Research 45*(19): 605-652.

SELECTED RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

"Urban ecosystem services in decline: The cost of urban expansion in U.S. metropolitan areas from 2001 to 2021" with Ben Janke, Justin A. Johnson, Yanxu Long, Eric Lonsdorf, Chris Nootenboom, and Stephen Polasky. **Conditionally Accepted at *Ecosystem Services.*** Preprint.

"Global Gross Ecosystem Product" with NatCap TEEMs. *In progress.*

"Sustainability indices: A review, taxonomy, and research agenda for transformative change" with Nfamara K. Dampha, Stephen Polasky, Michelle Heyn, Haku Bo, Yanxu Long, Adriana Castillo Castillo, Justin Johnson, Sumil Thakar, and Saleh Mamun. *In progress.*

PRESENTATIONS

"How Equitably Are Ecosystem Services Distributed in U.S. Metropolitan Areas?" (Dec. 2024). *A Community on Ecosystem Services Conference.* Austin, TX.

"Distributional ecosystem accounts: Incorporating environmental justice into federal Natural Capital Accounting." (June 2024). *United States Society for Ecological Economics 13th Conference.* Schenectady, NY.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Postdoctoral Research Associate, U. of Minnesota, Department of Applied Economics. 2026 - Present
Project: "Integrating ecosystem services into aquatic invasive species management."
PI: Amy Kinsley, DVM, Ph.D.

Graduate Research Assistant, University of Minnesota, Department of Applied Economics. 2025 - 2026
Project: "Spatial Economic Allocation Landscape Simulator for Net Zero Brazil."
Supervisor: Justin A. Johnson

Graduate Research Assistant, Dept. of the Interior, Office of Policy Analysis. 2023 - 2024
Project: "Accounting for Environmental Justice & Equity within Natural Capital Accounts."
UMN Supervisor: Stephen Polasky
DOI Supervisor: Robert Richardson

Graduate Research Assistant, University of Minnesota, Center on Women, Gender, & Public Policy. 2021
Project: "Status of Women & Girls in Minnesota Report."
Supervisor: Christina Ewig

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Full-Time Instructor, Economics & Political Science Dept., St. Catherine University. 2024 - 2025
ECON 1090: Statistical Analysis for Decision-making (5 sections)
ECON/CARR 2012: Personal Financial Fitness
CORE 1000W: The Reflective Woman

Graduate Teaching Assistant, Applied Economics Dept., University of Minnesota. 2021 - 2022
APEC 8001-02: Applied Microeconomic Analysis
APEC 1101 & 1101H (honors): Principles of Microeconomics

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

Graduate Scholar Program, Institute on the Environment, University of Minnesota. 2023 - 2024

Berkeley/Sloan Summer School in Environmental and Energy Economics, UC Berkeley. 2023

COMMUNITY INVOLVEMENT

NatCap The Earth Economy Modelers, University of Minnesota. 2020 - Present

Advisory Board, Minnesota Center for Diversity in Economics (MCDE). 2020 - Present

Women in APEC, Dept. of Applied Economics, University of Minnesota. 2023 - 2026

Communications Committee, Dept. of Applied Economics, University of Minnesota. 2022 - 2023

C-FEM Mentorship Program (for a total of 15 young women in economics), MCDE. 2020 - 2023

HONORS & AWARDS

2025 Borealis Award for Exemplary Student Organization (graduate). College of Food, Agricultural and Natural Resource Sciences, University of Minnesota.

2022-2023 Graduate Assistant Teaching Award. College of Food, Agricultural and Natural Resource Sciences, University of Minnesota.

2021-2022 Teaching Assistant Award for 1000 Level Classes. Dept. of Applied Economics, U. of Minnesota.

2020-2021 Mary A. and Robert B. Litterman Endowed Fellowship. Dept. of Applied Economics, U. of Minnesota.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Programming Languages: Python, R, TeX.
Software & Platforms: QGIS, Google Earth Engine, HPC Systems (e.g., MSI Supercomputer), Stata.